

see also same title 'Addenda'

in VT 41 (1991)

127-128

(not here)

FIRST PERSON IMPERFECT FORMS WITH WAW CONSECUTIVE

by

E. J. REVELL

Toronto

First person imperfect forms with *waw* consecutive have recently received some attention in connection with the question of the authorship of the books of Ezra, Nehemiah, and Chronicles.¹ A few details of these forms were overlooked in that discussion. It seems worth while to present these, in case similar interest in these forms is aroused in some other connection.² Forms with pronominal suffixes, which show no variations that might give clues to date or authorship, are not included in the following description.

(1) Where *alef* is the final root letter, the same 3 ms. form is regularly used with *waw* consecutive as without. This is also true for 1st person forms in 56 cases (including the *qere* in Josh. xxiv 8). The four exceptional forms, *wʔəṣṣʔh* (Neh. ii 13), *wʔəqrʔh* (1 Sam. xxviii 15), and the *ketib* forms *wʔbʔh* (Josh. xxiv 8), and *wʔwsʔh* (Ezra viii 17), all appear to reflect the use of the affix *-ʔh*. This affixed form of the imperfect thus occurs in *waw* consecutive forms from roots with final *alef* much less frequently than in forms from any other roots except those with final *he*. This is to be expected, since this use of the affix is late (see below), and the differences between the two types of final weak root had been lost by the end of the biblical period.³

¹ The debate was initiated by S. Japhet in "The supposed common authorship of Chronicles and Ezra-Nehemiah investigated anew", *VT* 18 (1968), pp. 330-71. The linguistic components of this and subsequent arguments on the question were evaluated in M. A. Throntveit "Linguistic analysis and the question of authorship in Chronicles, Ezra, and Nehemiah", *VT* 32 (1982), pp. 201-16.

² Any increase in the accuracy of this description of forms over others is due to the use of a list of forms beginning *wʔ-* or *wann-* provided by "Promotion bibli-que et informatique" of Maredsous. A few forms were noticed which had not been included, however, so it cannot be asserted that this description is complete.

³ The affixed 1st person form is also much less common in forms from roots III² than from other roots where a modal is expected. The affix occurs in 1 of 6

(2) Where the final root letter is *he*, the 3 ms. *waw* consecutive imperfect form is typically apocopated, although forms retaining the final vowel also occur. The corresponding 1 s. form is apocopated in 49 cases, but retains the final vowel in 57. The corresponding 1 pl. form is apocopated in 8 cases, but retains the final vowel in 6.

(3) The 3 ms. *waw* consecutive imperfect form regularly differs from the ordinary imperfect in stress position or vowel pattern in forms from hollow roots (except *bwʕ*), geminate roots, many forms from roots with initial *alef* or *yod*, and in *hifʕil* forms from other roots.⁴ The corresponding 1 s. form shows the affix *-ah* in 41 cases. Where this affix is not used, 1 s. forms with *waw* consecutive differ from ordinary imperfect forms in stress position only through *nesiga* (retraction of the stress, as in 1 Kgs xxi 6; Isa. xli 9; Ezek. xvi 6, 6). The 1 s. form differs from the ordinary imperfect in vowel quality in *wʕʕlek* (Lev. xxvi 13; Dt. xxix 4; Josh. xxiv 3; Amos ii 10), also *wʕʕseb* (Josh. xiv 7, but not *wʕʕsib* in Neh. vi 4, and other similar forms) and *wʕʕed* (Jer. xxxii 10, but not *wʕʕid* in 1 Kgs ii 42). The 1 s. form with *waw* consecutive is the same as that of the ordinary imperfect in 158 cases. The corresponding 1 pl. form shows the affix *-ah* in Ps. xc 10; Ezra viii 23. Where this affix is not used, the 1 pl. form with *waw* consecutive shows the same vowel and stress pattern as the 3 ms. form with *waw* consecutive in 25 cases. The vowel and stress pattern is the same as that of the ordinary imperfect only in *wannaʕamid* in Neh. iv 3.

(4) With other roots and stems, the same 3 ms. imperfect form is typically used with *waw* consecutive as without. This is true of

expected cases where the *alef* was preceded by short *a (the ambiguous *ʕepʕah*, Jer. iii 22, is not included), 2/6 where it was preceded by short *i, and in 8/12 *qal* forms from BW². The affix is "expected" before *nʕ*, after *ʕl*, or in sequence with another modal form. (The rule established by H. M. Orlinsky in "On the Cohortative and Jussive after an Imperative", *JQR* N.S. 31 [1940-41], pp. 371-82; 32 [1941-42], pp. 191-205, 273-7, is true for modal imperfects as well as imperatives.) The affix might also be expected in some cases where markers of this sort do not occur, but even this conservative assessment shows that the use of the affixed form with these roots was progressively lost under phonological conditioning. It must be said, however, that affixed forms occur less regularly than do short forms with other roots also, as is shown by the exceptions listed in Orlinsky's article (pp. 194-201).

⁴ Such difference also occurs in some forms with open penultimate syllable from the *nifʕal*, *piʕel*, or *hitpaʕel* stem, but this is not regular. Forms from these stems are included in category (4) to keep the situation in (3) as clear as possible, as are 1st person forms corresponding to 3rd person forms in which penultimate stress might be expected, but does not occur, as *wayyiqas*, *watleqal*.

the corresponding 1 s. forms in 130 cases. In a further 44 cases, the 1 s. form with *waw* consecutive shows the affix *-yh*. The corresponding 1 pl. form with *waw* consecutive is the same as that of the ordinary imperfect in 22 cases. It shows the affix *-yh* in a further 4 cases.

The use of the affix *-yh* in categories (3) and (4) is common only in later materials. It occurs in 61% of the possible cases in Daniel, Ezra and Nehemiah (55 of 90 cases), compared to about 4% in the Pentateuch (4/92), and the Latter Prophets (6/154). Its distribution is, however, remarkably uneven. It occurs in 5/12 cases in Judges, and 5/9 cases in 2 Samuel, but in only 1/45 cases in the rest of the Former Prophets. It occurs in 10 of 11 cases in Ps. iii, vii, lxix, xc, cxix, but in none of the other six cases in Psalms. It occurs in all four cases in the prose of Job (Job i), but in none of the five cases in the poetry. It does not occur in the books of Chronicles.⁵ The distribution is similarly uneven in Nehemiah. The affix *-yh* is used in 4 of 9 cases (44%) in i 1-ii 9, and in 25/30 (83%) in v 1-xiii 31, but in none of the 18 cases in ii 10-20 and iv.⁶

This use of the affix *-yh* on 1st person forms with *waw* consecutive is characteristic of a post-exilic form of literary (biblical) Hebrew which became standard at Qumran, and influenced the Samaritan Pentateuch much more strongly than it did that of the MT.⁷ Ben Hayyim has connected this usage with a tendency to use the affixed form without *waw* consecutive (the "cohortative") with time reference other than future.⁸ Of the examples of the usage that he gives, however, only that in Ps. lxvi 6 is atypical for an imperfect form, and in Daniel, Ezra and Nehemiah the use of the affixed

⁵ So correctly Japhet, p. 338, as before her A. Kropat, *Die Syntax des Autors der Chronik verglichen mit der seiner Quellen* (Giessen, 1909), p. 75. In disagreeing with them, R. Polzin in *Late Biblical Hebrew* (Missoula, 1976), p. 54, and Throntveit, p. 204, appear slightly to misunderstand their sources. G. Bergsträsser, *Hebräische Grammatik* (Leipzig, 1918-1929) II, § 5 e, lists cases where *waw* prefixed to a 1st person imperfect form beginning with *alef* with *hatef patah* is vowelled with *patah*, but appears to be "consecutive". If these are included, the figure for the first group of Psalms is 11/13, for the second, 1/7, and for the poetry of Job, 1/6. (The cases from Judges listed have *qames* in the Leningrad Codex.)

⁶ Note, however, that *wəʔesəʔh* occurs in ii 13; see category (1). There are no cases in Neh. iii. The first affixed form with *waw* consecutive after this section occurs in v 7.

⁷ See E. Qimron, *The Hebrew of the Dead Sea Scrolls* (Atlanta, 1986), p. 45, § 310.129.

⁸ Z. Ben Hayyim, *The Literary and Oral Tradition of Hebrew and Aramaic amongst the Samaritans V, Grammar of the Pentateuch* (Jerusalem, 1977) § 2.9.10.

form without *waw* consecutive is consistent with the classical cohortative use (Dan. i 12; Neh. v 2, 2, 10, vi 7, 10; cf. the long forms from roots III $\dot{h}$ in Dan. i 12; Ezra iv 2; Neh. ii 17, v 2). It seems more likely that the use of the affixed form with *waw* consecutive reflects the fact that this form was perceived as the equivalent, in the 1st person, of the short imperfect form in the 2nd and 3rd person.

The short imperfect form (unless preceded by the negative לֹא) is characteristically used at the beginning of a clause, whether with *waw* consecutive, or without, as 2nd or 3rd person modal.⁹ The semantic contrast modal/indicative originally marked by the short and long imperfect forms was abandoned during the biblical period.¹⁰ The standard use of the contrasting forms was, however, continued, so that the short and long forms acted as allomorphs, the use of which was conditioned by the position of the verb in the clause. This is seen in Dan. xi, where imperfects appear in short form at the beginning of a clause whether jussive or indicative value is expected. Within a clause, long forms are used. The only exception is the *qere* form in Dan. xi 10. First person modals, the affixed imperfect forms, also characteristically begin their clauses. All examples in Daniel, Ezra, and Nehemiah, can be understood as having modal value, but it is clear that, in the late biblical period, the formal contrast between affixed and ordinary imperfect forms no longer distinguished modal from indicative value, and the same is true at Qumran (Qimron, p. 44). It is reasonable to suppose,

⁹ In standard biblical prose, short or affixed imperfect forms begin clauses (except where preceded by לֹא); long imperfects do not, with negligible exceptions. Thus the modal/indicative contrast is marked by position in the clause. Consequently B. Johnson finds only three 2nd person imperfects with conjunctive *waw* (necessarily clause-initial) in the whole of the Pentateuch and Former Prophets (*Hebräisches Perfekt und Imperfekt mit vorangehendem waw* [Lund, 1979], p. 57), because imperatives carry the modal function in affirmative clauses with 2nd person verbs (Bergsträsser, II § 10a).

¹⁰ The extent of semantic distinction is questionable even in the classical form of the language; see B. Zuber, *Das Tempussystem des biblischen Hebräisch*, BZAW 164 (Berlin, 1968), pp. 145-6, also E. Talstra, "Text Grammar and Hebrew Bible II", *Bi Or* 39 (1982), col. 31, who argues (if I understand him correctly) that the semantic distinction is not marked by verb forms, but by features of their context. However, modal imperfects are clearly and consistently distinguished from indicatives (n. 9 above). I would argue that this formal/syntactic distinction must be held to reflect a distinction in function, even if that function is not consistent with "universal" semantic categories. Cf. S. R. Driver *A Treatise on the Use of the Tenses in Hebrew* (3rd edn, Oxford, 1892), p. 212.

then, that these affixed forms came to be perceived as positional variants of the ordinary imperfect, equivalent to the short forms in 2nd and 3rd person. Consequently the affixed forms were also used with *waw* consecutive.¹¹

The use of affixed 1st person forms with *waw* consecutive represents, then, a syntactic or semantic development which was standardized in a post-exilic form of literary Hebrew. It is possible that some parts of the Bible were written in a Hebrew of this sort in which the standardization of this usage was either less complete than at Qumran, or has been obscured by later change. In the book of Nehemiah, however, the use of these forms distinguishes sections different from those of the usual literary division based on content and style. If the latter division is justified, the use of affixed 1st person forms with *waw* consecutive shown in the MT must have arisen during the process of transmission. This conclusion must apply to the use of these forms throughout the Bible. They cannot be taken, in any book, as certainly representing the language of the author.

The long form of the 1st person imperfect from roots IIIh is regularly used where a cohortative form is expected. The use of long 1st person forms from these roots with *waw* consecutive is more common in later materials, and shows a distribution generally similar to that of affixed 1st person forms from other roots with *waw* consecutive. Such long forms are not used with *waw* consecutive in any of the five possible cases in Neh. ii 10-20 and iv. They are used in one of two cases in Neh. i 1-ii 9, and in all four cases in the rest of the book. They occur in 1/2 cases in Judges, in all five in 2 Samuel, in 2/3 cases in Ps. lxxix (there are no cases in the other Psalms listed above) and in 1/2 cases in the poetry of Job. Consequently the use of the long form of the 1st person imperfect with *waw* consecutive in roots IIIh can reasonably be regarded as representing the same development as does the use of the affixed form in other roots. The use of long 1st person forms is, however, much more common generally than is that of affixed forms. Long

¹¹ Throntveit (p. 203), referring to a note by Cross in *JBL* 93 (1975), p. 14, n. 58, suggests that some forms discussed by Japhet may be (pseudo-) archaisms or orthographic variations. Neither he nor Cross specifically mentions the affixed forms with *waw* consecutive, but it may be worth pointing out that the use of an existing form in a new way is a common feature of natural linguistic development, not an archaism, and that, if the variation were merely orthographic, one would expect a significant proportion of affixed forms to occur within the clause.

1st person forms are used with *waw* consecutive in 3/21 cases in the Pentateuch (14%), and in 23/47 in the Latter Prophets (49%). The use of long 2 ms. or 3 s. imperfect forms with *waw* consecutive, or after the negative ׀ (where short forms are expected) is much more common with roots IIIh than with other roots, and a similar unmotivated variation occurs in the 2 ms. imperative forms from the derived stems. No doubt confusion arising from these variations affected the use of the long first person forms.

First person forms in category (3) on which the affix -*h* is not used show the following general pattern. Stress is penultimate where the penultimate syllable is open, but both antepenultimate and final syllables are closed.¹² Stress is final where either antepenultimate or final syllable is open as well as the penultimate. Stress is also final where the penultimate syllable is closed, including cases where a guttural which originally closed it has a *ḥatef* in the MT.

Where stress is penultimate, the reflex of original **u* in a final closed syllable is *qameṣ*, that of original **i* is *segol*, as in the corresponding 3 ms. forms (where other reflexes also occur under conditions not found in the 1st person forms under consideration). Where stress is final, the reflex of **u* is *qibbuṣ* or *shureq* in a final closed syllable. The reflex of **i* is *sere* where the penultimate syllable is closed. The only exception is *wannaʿamid* in Neh. iv 3. Where the penultimate syllable is open, the reflex is *sere* or *pataḥ* in forms from roots Iʔ and Iy, including the four cases of the *hiṣʿil* form *wʔōlek*.¹³ The reflex is also *sere* in two forms from hollow roots. In other hollow root and *hiṣʿil* forms, the reflex is *hireq*.

Where stress is penultimate, the vowel of a final closed syllable is represented by a vowel letter only in *wnšwb* (Neh. iv 9). Where stress is final, MT *u* or *i* in a final closed syllable is (a) never written with a vowel letter in the Pentateuch (4 cases), Joshua (1), Judges (1), 1 Kings (4), Jeremiah (3), and also Isaiah (2 cases according to the Aleppo Codex, and the Masorah of the Leningrad Codex, but not its text in Isa. li 16), (b) always represented by a vowel letter in 1 Samuel (3), Amos (2), Malachi (1), Daniel (1), and Nehemiah

¹² The same conditions hold for 3rd person forms, including the *nifʿal* and *hitpaʿel* forms which show penultimate stress with *waw* consecutive, and probably for the *piʿel* forms also, following Bergsträsser, I, § 24 f.

¹³ The vowel in question also acts as short before the affix -*h* in a form of this sort in *wʔōsərḥ* (Neh. xiii 13), but not in *wʔōšīʿh* (Judg. x 12).

(13), (c) sometimes represented in Ezekiel (3 of 6 cases), Zechariah (1/3), and Chronicles (3/4).

It seems clear that the stress patterns of these forms reflect a natural phonological development in which stress position was conditioned by syllable structure. The exception in Neh. iv 3 forms a negligible proportion even of 1st person forms. The vowel patterns suggest a correspondingly regular development. The vowel of a final closed syllable in these forms originally acted as short. In hollow root forms, and in *hiʿil* forms from other roots, the vowel of this syllable changed in quality in all forms but those in which both penultimate and antepenultimate syllable were open (with the few exceptions noted). Where the vowel of this final closed syllable was stressed *u* or *i*, it was, in later times, often marked with a vowel letter, but there is no way of knowing to what extent the use of these letters in any part of the MT represents that of the work in its original form.

The use, in category (3), of long first person singular forms with *waw* consecutive is thus due to a phonological development quite distinct from the syntactic/semantic development which led to the use of affixed first person forms, both singular and plural, in categories (1), (3), and (4), and most probably also the use of long first person forms, also both singular and plural, in category (2). Both developments appear to have occurred towards the end of the biblical period, but there is no adequate basis for dating them either absolutely or relative to each other. The lack of relationship between the two developments is made clear (apart from the fact that both occur in category (3)) by the occurrence of two exceptional long 1st person forms with *waw* consecutive in Neh. iv 3 and iv 9, in a passage characterized by the failure to use affixed forms. Less striking confirmation is provided by the regular use of vowel letters in the final closed syllable of forms from category (3) in 1 Samuel (x 18, xii 1, xxviii 21) where an affixed form occurs in only one of twelve possible cases (or 4/15 if long *IIIh* forms are included).

This survey has, then, the negative merit of stressing the dangers of using 1st person forms with *waw* consecutive as criteria of authorship. The use of affixed forms cannot be attributed with any confidence to any biblical author. The use of long 1 s. forms from hollow roots (and others in category (3)) was characteristic of later biblical Hebrew generally. This represents a development separate from that which gave rise to the use of affixed forms, not a different

aspect of it. The usual description of first person forms with *waw* consecutive in terms such as "The 1 s. imperfect with *waw* consecutive usually has the same form as the ordinary imperfect" (so Bergsträsser, II, § 5d; cf. Japhet, p. 334) applies only to these category (3) forms. The use of long forms from roots III $\hbar$ is probably an aspect of the use of affixed forms, but is in any case not related to the use of long forms in category (3), as it is not restricted to singular forms. The demonstration of the need for this minor adjustment in the standard description of Biblical Hebrew is a more positive result for the paper.

division (#18.5), or before a word stressed on its first syllable (#18.6e). That is, the development of final stress is blocked in all forms at the end of a clause-level unit. Position within such a unit is conducive to the development of final stress, but whether or not this occurs is dependent on the internal structure of the unit, the significant factors being the structure of the verb form, the nature of the following sound, and also the position of the verb relative to the last main stress in a "phrase-level" subdivision of the unit. The distinction made in Blau (1971, #5.4) between a "shift" to final stress shown in forms with a closed penultimate, and a "tendency" to such a shift in other forms, although of course based on accurate observation, is arbitrary, and obscures the larger picture.

27 Stress position in perfect forms with *waw* consecutive is, then, conditioned by the intonation patterns characteristic of the speech units into which the text was divided (in one form of the reading tradition) according to the syntactic, (other) semantic, and rhythmic factors described. Whether or not these intonation patterns induce final stress in a verb form at a given position in a unit is determined by the phonological structure of the unit. Because our information comes from a written source which does not represent these intonation patterns (see #12), it is not possible to provide a comprehensive, precise, and objective description of the boundaries of the units, let alone a description of their structure. However, the relation of stress position to the syntactic, semantic, and rhythmic factors is sufficiently clear that there can be no doubt that the variation in stress position in these forms represents one of the many facets of the influence of these intonation patterns on the vowelling and stress position of the words of biblical Hebrew.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- Artom, E. S. 1958. "The Accent of the Consecutive Perfect of Verbs *tertia* ³ and *h*." *Leshonenu* 22:205-208.
- Ben David, Y. 1984. "Pausal Forms in Verses Lacking the ³*Etnahta*³ in the Twenty-One Books." *Textus* 11:51-63.
- Bergsträsser, G. 1929. *Hebräische Grammatik*, II Teil. Leipzig.
- Blau, J. 1971. "The General Background of the Stress Shift in the Perfect with *Waw* Consecutive" (= "Marginalia Semitica 5"). *Israel Oriental Studies* 1:15-24.
- Driver, S. R. 1892. *A Treatise on the Use of the Tenses in Hebrew*³. Edinburgh.

- Ginsburg, C. D. 1926. *The Old Testament . . . with the Various Readings from MSS.* London.
- Gordon, C. H. 1938. "The Accentual Shift in the Perfect with *Waw* Consecutive." *Journal of Biblical Literature* 57:319-325.
- Huesman, J. 1956. "The Infinitive Absolute and the *Waw* + Perfect Problem." *Biblica* 37:410-434.
- Loretz, O. 1961. "The *Perfectum Copulativum* in 2 Sam 7, 9-11." *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 23:294-296.
- Mayer, R. 1959. "Auffallender Erzählungsstil in einem angeblichen Auszug aus der 'Chronik der Könige von Juda'." *Festschrift Friedrich Baumgärtel*, ed. J. Herrmann (Erlanger Forschungen, Reihe A, Bd 10) Erlangen, p. 114-123.
- McFall, L. 1982. "The Tone Shift in 1st and 2nd Persons Masc. Sing. *wqtl*-forms" and "The Determining Influence of the Syntactical Context on the Position of the Verbal Tone" = Appendix 2, pp. 189-210 in L. McFall, *The Enigma of the Hebrew Verbal System*. Sheffield.
- Revell, E. J. 1980. "Pausal Forms in Biblical Hebrew: their Function, Origin, and Significance." *Journal of Semitic Studies* 25:165-179.
- . 1981. "Syntactic/Semantic Structure and the Reflexes of Original Short *a* in Tiberian Pointing." *Hebrew Annual Review* 5:75-100.
- . 1983. "*Nesiga* and the History of the Masorah." *Estudios Masoréticos* pp. 37-48 (= *Textos y Estudios* 33). Madrid.
- . 1984. "Stress and the *Waw* 'Consecutive' in Biblical Hebrew." *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 104:437-444.
- Yeivin, I. 1980. *Introduction to the Tiberian Masorah*. Missoula.